rural masses, arguing that ‘if you say that you will approach the peasants and labourers to enlist their active support’ then

> [t]hey ask you quite candidly: what are they going to gain by your revolution for which you demand their sacrifices, what difference does it make to them whether Lord Reading is the head of the Indian government of Sir Purshotamdas Thakordas? What difference for a peasant if Sir Tej Bahadur Sapru replaces Lord Irwin! It is useless to appeal to his national sentiment.

Being against such use and abuse of the masses, Bhagat Singh argued for ‘the revolution of the proletariat and for the proletariat’.[2] In a veiled attack on Gandhi, he argued that ‘the policy of voluntarily going to jail should altogether be abandoned’.[3]

Bhagat Singh would definitely not have endeared himself to Mahatma Gandhi when he talked of the ‘mental stagnation’ that inhibits ‘criticism and independent thinking’, which are ‘the two indispensable qualities of a revolutionary’ and he was scathing about a mentality whereby,

> Because MahatmaJi is great, therefore none should criticise him. Because he has risen above, therefore everything he says – may be in the field of Politics or Religion, Economics, or Ethics – is right. Whether you are convinced or not you must say: ‘Yes, that’s true’. This mentality does not lead towards progress.[4]

Bhagat Singh also strongly disagreed with Gandhi’s own personal attitude to the Indian peasantry whom he disfavoured over the middle-class. When advising the young political workers, Bhagat Singh was very critical of the ‘middle class shopkeepers and a few capitalists’ who he said ‘can never dare to risk its property or possessions in any struggle.’, Whilst Gandhi overlooked the poor and the disenfranchised, Bhagat Singh’s view was that, ‘the real revolutionary forces have not been invited into the arena’. As he explained, ‘The real revolutionary armies are in the villages and in factories, the peasantry and the labourers. But our bourgeois leaders do not and cannot dare to tackle them.’[5] As a result, he is openly critical of Gandhi. This is because,

> After his first experience with the Ahmedabad labourers in 1920 Mahatma Gandhi declared: ‘We must not tamper with the labourers. It is dangerous to make political use of